

You keep meaning to cancel something you don't use

8 findings · 11-step checklist · 6 sources · cheatgrid.com

Nothing about your day forces a decision on a subscription you already decided against, so it renews by default. **Deciding isn't the hard part**; nothing is making today different from tomorrow.

THE GOAL

You're making today the day the charge stops. Open the account or app where you manage it, without weighing the decision again.

CHECKLIST

You've decided today is the day you're actually going to deal with this subscription, and you're sitting down to do it.

- ☐ Skip weighing whether to keep it again, you've already decided: **go straight to** the account or app where you manage this subscription.
- ☐ Find the exact charge and confirm the amount and the billing date before doing anything else.
- ☐ Check for a last-used or last-login date on the account; if there is none, use the last time you clearly remember opening it.
- ☐ Check whether cancelling now stops it immediately or lets the current period run out, so you know which to expect.
- ☐ Look specifically for the cancel or turn-off-auto-renew control, since closing the app or deleting your login does not always stop billing.
- ☐ If a screen offers a pause, a lower price, or a downgrade to keep you, decline it and continue toward cancelling.
- ☐ If a thought like "what if I need this later" stops you, say "I can sign up again if that happens" and **keep going**.
- ☐ Carry the cancellation through every step to its final confirmation screen; a single "cancel" click isn't the end of it.
- ☐ **Save the confirmation**, a screenshot, an email, or a reference number, somewhere you'll actually find again.
- ☐ Write down what this was, the date you cancelled it, and one line on why it went unused.
- ☐ Set a reminder for your next billing date to check the charge is actually gone.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** Something already selected tends to just stay selected. On average, the option someone already has gets picked about a quarter more often than the alternative.
- 2** Treat right now as the forced choice itself, and finish the cancellation.
- 3** Gym members who quit going still paid for **more than two months**, on average, before actually cancelling.

Why it keeps running on its own

KNOW

Something already selected tends to just stay selected. On average, the option someone already has gets picked about a quarter more often than the alternative.

That shift was large enough for the researchers to call defaults a strong tool for steering everyday decisions. [Source 1](#)

WATCH

Watch for the feeling that it doesn't matter much anymore. A default tends to keep the most control exactly when you care the least, not when you care the most.

A review of default effects found they often sway people more in choices they care about least, and everyday subscriptions sit in that zone. [Source 1](#)

DO

Treat right now as the forced choice itself, and finish the cancellation.

When something like a card expiring forces that same choice, many people who had already stopped wanting the subscription let it lapse right then. [Source 2](#)

Why this is not a personal failing

KNOW

About four in ten people have done exactly this: kept paying after they had already stopped using it.

Losing track like this is common enough among people asked directly about their own subscriptions to count as fully ordinary. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

Gym members who quit going still paid for **more than two months**, on average, before actually cancelling.

For one in five, that gap ran four months or longer, even though cancelling cost far less than staying enrolled. [Source 4](#)

What you're probably getting wrong about the risk

KNOW

People asked to predict their gym visits guessed about twice as many as members' actual attendance records show.

People in a separate mall survey predicted about nine visits a month; tracked members' actual attendance averaged about four. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

You probably have little sense of your real monthly total, and that makes each subscription look smaller than it is.

Consumers' own guesses missed their real spend by a wide margin, wider than the same question found a few years earlier. [Source 5](#)

DON'T

Don't keep paying just in case.

People who do end up resubscribing do it because a real need came back, not because a win-back offer talked them into it. [Source 6](#)

Sources

1. <https://behavioralscientist.org/defaults-are-not-the-same-by-default/>
2. <https://www.nber.org/digest/202310/consumer-inattention-and-subscription-renewals>
3. <https://www.crrresearch.com/blog/subscription-service-statistics-and-costs/>
4. <https://eml.berkeley.edu/~sdellavi/wp/gymemp06-03-19.pdf>
5. <https://www.westmonroe.com/press-releases/americans-are-spending-more-on-subscriptions-and-are-less-aware-of-spending>
6. <https://www.revenuecat.com/state-of-subscription-apps/>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Bills and subscriptions at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)